

LISTENING

#20

1 – Listen to an interview about how autonomous cars work. Pay attention to the different levels of automation, what current vehicles can actually do, and why some companies might be exaggerating their capabilities.

Driverless Cars

1 - Why does the man say many people feel confused about Teslas?

- a) The technology is still too new
- b) The company gives unclear information
- c) Drivers are not trained properly

2 - What does the man say Teslas are actually capable of?

- a) Level 5 autonomous driving
- b) Level 3 autonomous driving
- c) Level 2 autonomous driving

3 - Which feature is used as an example of Level 1 automation?

- a) The driver was not holding the steering wheel.
- b) The driver wasn't paying attention to the road.
- c) There was no driver.

4 - What does the man mention as examples of Level 2 features?

- a) Automatic emergency braking and lane centering
- b) Full hands-free highway driving
- c) Night-only autonomous mode

5 - At which level can a car technically drive itself but still needs full driver attention?

6 - According to the man, why is Level 3 considered dangerous?

- a) It is too slow
- b) Cars cannot detect obstacles
- c) There is no clear line between human and car control

7 - What do the speakers say about Tesla? [Choose 2 answers.]

- () Tesla is already producing Level 2 to Level 3 autonomous cars.
- () Tesla currently has some Level 4 cars on the road.
- () Tesla has been providing Uber with driverless cars.
- () Tesla claims it will release a Level 5 car in the next three years.

8 - What is the main topic of the conversation?

- a) The capabilities of autonomous driving
- b) The dangers of driverless cars
- c) The growth of Tesla

Full Name _____

READING COMPREHENSION

The evolving safety and policy challenges of self-driving cars

Self-driving taxis without safety drivers are already operating in several U.S. cities, including San Francisco, Phoenix, and Los Angeles. For many visitors, riding in one has even become a small tourist attraction. Supporters believe autonomous cars could eventually make roads safer, offer mobility to people who cannot drive, and reduce pollution thanks to smoother, more controlled driving.

Despite these potential benefits, major challenges remain. Policymakers in the U.S. have not developed a clear, unified regulatory system that proves self-driving cars are safe enough for widespread use. Although humans cause most traffic accidents, experts warn that it is a mistake to assume computers will automatically be safer. Self-driving cars rely on complex perception and prediction systems, and these systems can still make dangerous errors. A well-known example occurred in 2018, when an Uber vehicle in autonomous mode failed to correctly identify a pedestrian and caused a fatal accident. Other incidents linked to software glitches or misclassification of objects highlight the limits of the technology.

Some companies, like Waymo, have reported encouraging results in limited areas, showing lower rates of certain non-fatal accidents. However, these results apply only to specific zones where the cars have been heavily tested. To truly demonstrate that autonomous vehicles are as safe as humans, companies would need to collect far more data—likely hundreds of millions of miles.

For now, the most realistic future for autonomous vehicles is local, geofenced taxi services rather than privately owned, fully driverless cars. Public trust remains a significant barrier. Surveys show that many Americans feel uncertain or fearful about self-driving technology, and only a small percentage would consider purchasing an autonomous car.

Overall, while the technology is progressing, widespread adoption will require clearer regulations, stronger safety proof, and a higher level of public confidence.

Retrieved from: <https://www.brookings.edu/articles/the-evolving-safety-and-policy-challenges-of-self-driving-cars/>

Comprehension Questions

1. According to the text, what is one potential benefit of self-driving cars?

2. Why do experts say it is a mistake to assume computers will be safer than humans?

3. What is the most likely role of self-driving cars in the near future?

4. Would you feel safe using a self-driving taxi in your city? Why or why not?
